

Plants

There are around 400,000 species of plants on Earth. Plants make their food using sunlight, water, and carbon dioxide, and they are an important food source for all land animals. They also produce oxygen, which is vital to all life.

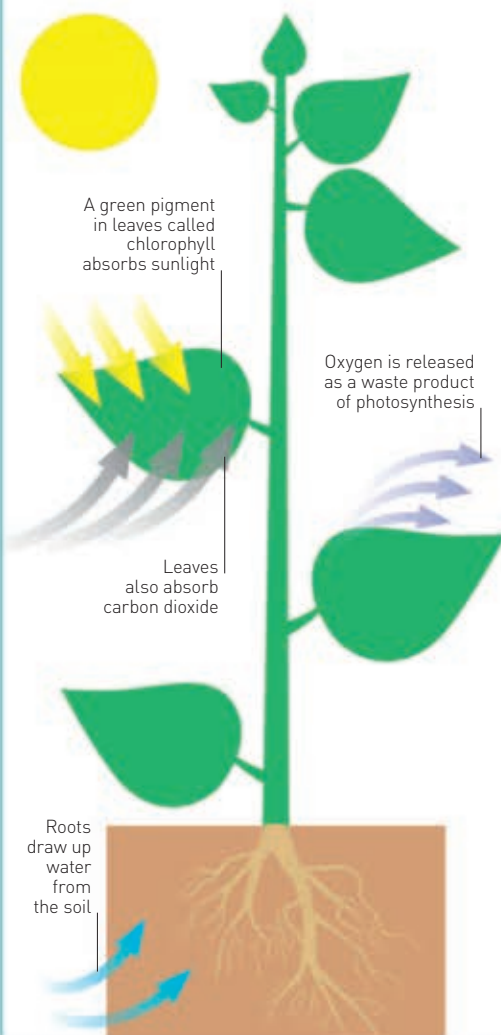
HOW PLANTS GROW

In spring, seeds get warm, absorb water, and start to sprout (germinate). Roots begin to grow downwards to get water and nutrients from the soil, while shoots grow upwards, towards the light.



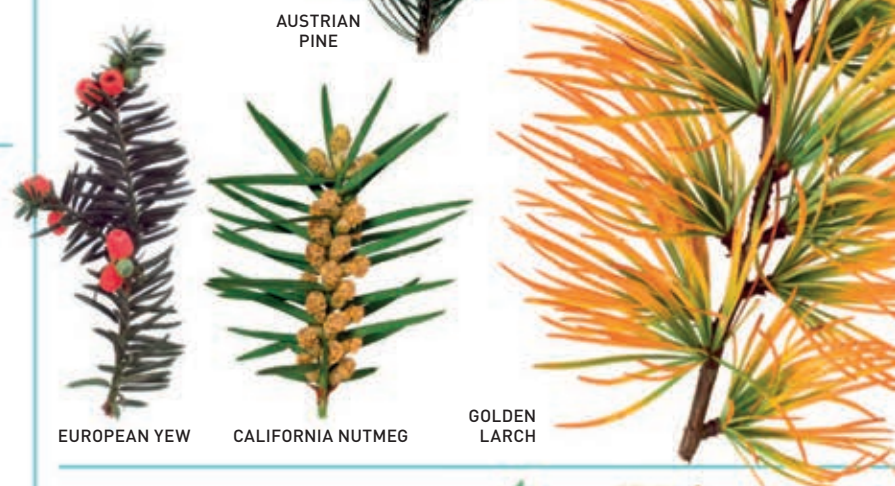
PHOTOSYNTHESIS

Plants make their own food (glucose) through a process called photosynthesis. They soak up water from the soil and take in carbon dioxide from the air. They then use the Sun's energy to produce glucose.



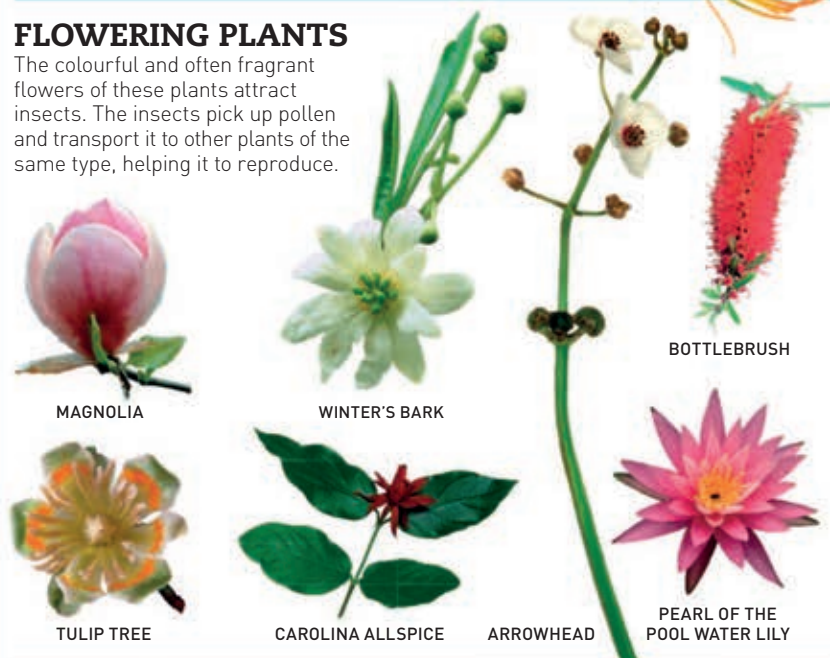
NON-FLOWERING PLANTS

These evergreen plants tend to like damp, shady places. They reproduce by releasing spores. Spores from coniferous plants are carried by the wind to special cones, where seeds develop.



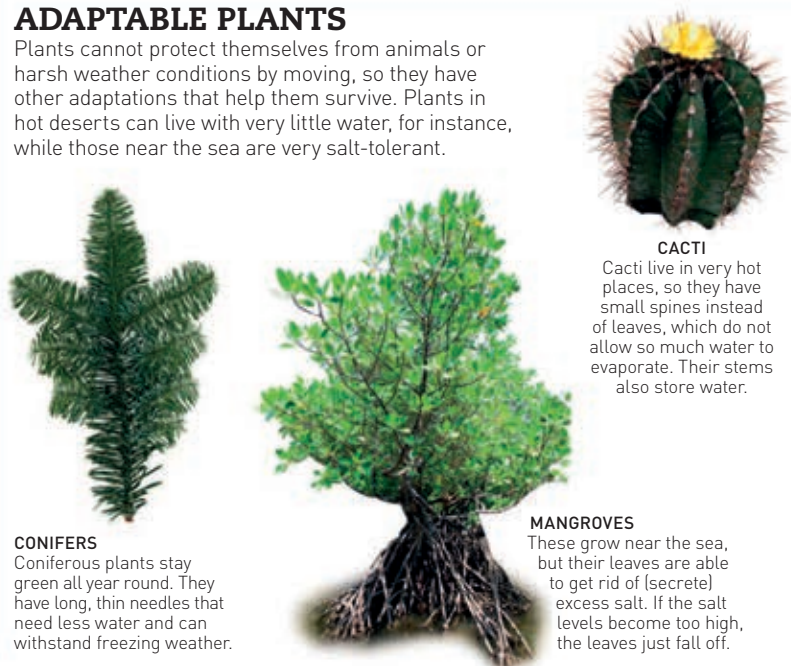
FLOWERING PLANTS

The colourful and often fragrant flowers of these plants attract insects. The insects pick up pollen and transport it to other plants of the same type, helping it to reproduce.



ADAPTABLE PLANTS

Plants cannot protect themselves from animals or harsh weather conditions by moving, so they have other adaptations that help them survive. Plants in hot deserts can live with very little water, for instance, while those near the sea are very salt-tolerant.



SEED DISPERSAL

Plants need to spread their seeds as far away from themselves as possible, so they do not end up overcrowded. There are different ways that seeds can be dispersed.

